

SECTION SIX

RELIGION, MYTH & PROPHECY

Faith, vows, divine purpose, forbidden love, crisis of belief, prophecy vs. choice

What do your characters believe about gods, death, destiny, and what it all means? The way a person thinks about religion guides their morals, creates a sense of community, defines their identity, and provides them with the type of stories they create for themselves. In your world, religious beliefs may have an actual literal effect on the lives of those who live there: gods who answer prayers, prophecies that come to pass, divine magic that proves faith isn't just faith. And in romantasy, religion does something no other worldbuilding element can. It allows for romantic love to feel sinful, for self-sacrifice to be seen as saving grace, and for making the "wrong" choice to feel like you have damned your own soul.

The Altar Principle

Every religion has an altar. A place where you have to lay something down. An offering, a sacrifice, a vow.

When it comes to romantasy, the thing that is put on the altar is love. The question is whether it's the offering or the sacrifice.

Religion creates obstacles that feel different from every other kind. Rulers change, social issues can be overcome with a new group of people, but religious obstacles feel absolute, because they come from God, or the gods, or the fundamental structure of the universe. When a character defies religious law for love, they're not just breaking a rule. They're sinning. They're not just disappointing their family. They're risking their very soul. They're not just choosing love over duty. They're choosing love over everything they believe about how the world works.

This is why it is so great, and also so simple to screw up.

The problem lies in making religion an obstacle to be overcome, a wall to climb, and then once you've made it to the top, forgetting that it was there. But faith isn't a wall. It's a world. It gives comfort in death, meaning in pain, community in isolation, identity when everything else has been taken away. When your character sacrifices these things for love, the reader needs to understand the magnitude of what is being lost. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou literally stands at the Church's altar when she marries Reid, a witch-hunter. She's the sacrifice the institution demands. In *Priory of the Orange Tree*, Ead has to decide between her sacred vows to the Priory and her love for Sabran, and the altar is the order itself, everything she has spent her life training for. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy has always been raised as the Maiden, a living offering to the gods, her entire identity built on being the sacrifice.

Create a religion that is important enough for your characters to fight for, against, or to redefine entirely. Then force your characters to the altar.

What is your character's altar — the thing they're forced to lay down?

*The altar is the sacrifice your religion demands. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou is literally the sacrifice the Church demands. In *Priory*, Ead must lay down her sisterhood and sacred purpose. What does your character have to give up — and is love the offering (what they place on the altar willingly) or the sacrifice (what the altar takes from them)?*

YOUR ANSWER

How to Think About Religion in Romantasy

Religion creates romantic tension through three channels, and each one operates at a different level:

The Three Channels of Religious Tension

CHANNEL	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
Divine Law	Religious doctrine that prohibits or requires: forbidden marriages, required unions, celibacy vows, purity requirements	Consequences that aren't just social but spiritual, including damnation, loss of divine favour, cosmic transgression
Sacred Duty	Religious obligations that compete with love: vows that bind, chosen one status, priestly duties, divine purpose	The agonising choice between what the gods demand and what the heart wants
Faith Itself	The internal spiritual dimension: genuine belief that makes violation feel like sin, the crisis when love conflicts with doctrine	The most profound conflict: not "should I break this rule?" but "is everything I believed a lie?"

Religious Situations That Create Romance Tension

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The forbidden union	Religious law prohibits their marriage	Sin, damnation stakes, crisis of faith
The vow of celibacy	One has sworn to the gods not to love	Temptation, breaking vows, questioning calling

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The interfaith lovers	Different religions that oppose each other	Conversion pressure, family opposition, whose god wins
The chosen one	Divine destiny that love interferes with	Duty vs. desire, sacrifice, questioning prophecy
The priest and the profane	Holy figure loves someone “beneath” their calling	Scandal, fall from grace, redefining holiness
The prophesied union	Fated to be together by divine decree	Is it real love or just destiny? Agency questions
The divine punishment	Their love angers the gods	Curses, divine intervention, appeasing deity
The sacred veil	One character hides a forbidden faith or magical nature from the other	Near-miss tension, the charged revelation moment, intimacy through shared sacrilege
The heretic beloved	The love interest IS what the religion condemns, not rule-breaking but ontological taboo	Epistemic crisis, moral identity collapse, forced reclassification of “evil”

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question here will apply to your story. Skip what doesn’t serve you.

If religion is background in your world, keep it simple. Not every romantasy needs theological complexity. If your world has no gods or organised religion, adapt or skip. And if you’re drawing on real religions, be thoughtful about what you’re borrowing and whether your portrayal is respectful.

Common Mistakes with Religious Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Convenient Religion

Religious rules exist to create obstacles, but they're inconsistently applied. The church forbids their marriage, but a friendly priest marries them anyway with no consequences. Religious law gets invoked when the plot needs tension and conveniently forgotten when it doesn't. Or worse, the character is revealed to be a literal god by the final act, and the religious obstacles that drove the first half of the story simply evaporate because the protagonist now has the power to rewrite reality. If religious obstacles can be conveniently circumvented, they have no weight. Readers stop believing religion matters in your world, which means every future religious obstacle feels hollow. In the later *From Blood and Ash* books, Poppy's evolution from oppressed Maiden to Primal God effectively removes the systemic obstacles the narrative spent its first book establishing. The difficult work of social reconciliation gets replaced by the literal power of a deity to reshape the world.

FIX

Make religious consequences real. Finding a way around should require genuine sacrifice or risk. The friendly priest who performs the forbidden marriage faces excommunication. The character who breaks a sacred vow loses their magic, their community, their place in the world. The earned resolutions in romantasy, like Xingyin's life force sacrifice in *Daughter of the Moon Goddess* or Reid's loss of his identity as a Chasseur in *Serpent & Dove*, work precisely because the characters pay a real price.

Mistake #2: The Strawman Faith

The religion that creates obstacles is obviously corrupt, cruel, or foolish. The only devout characters are villains or fools. The faith exists solely to be wrong so the protagonist can be right for defying it. If the religion is clearly wrong, choosing love over faith is obviously correct. There's no internal conflict needed. The reader never doubts what the character should do, which means the choice carries no tension.

FIX

Make the faith sympathetic even when it creates obstacles. Good people should believe it for understandable reasons. The priest who opposes the union isn't cruel; they genuinely believe they're protecting the character's soul. *Priory of the Orange Tree* avoids the strawman by making the Priory's mission real and urgent. The threat of the Nameless One means the vow of service isn't arbitrary. Ead's order exists for good reason, which is exactly why leaving it costs so much. Tension comes from genuinely conflicting goods, not from good versus obvious evil.

Mistake #3: The Painless Faith Departure

A character raised in deep faith abandons it easily once love appears. Their entire belief system dissolves without grief or struggle. They walk away from their religion as if shrugging off a coat. Faith isn't just rules. It's identity, community, and worldview. Losing it should hurt. If it doesn't, the faith was never real, which means the obstacle was never real. **Check your story against these three mistakes.** *If you've already started building your religion, run it through this quick diagnostic. If you haven't, come back to this after you've completed the exercises below.* | Mistake | Could This Apply to Your Story? | How You'd Fix It | |---|-----|-----| | *The Convenient Religion — religious rules exist but are bypassed without real cost* | Yes — *I have a "friendly priest" figure who helps them get around the marriage ban, and I haven't thought about what that costs the priest* | Give the priest real consequences for helping: excommunication, loss of community, personal guilt | | *The Convenient Religion — religious rules exist but are bypassed without real cost* | | | | *The Strawman Faith — the religion is obviously corrupt and no reasonable person would believe it* | | | | *The Painless Faith Departure — a character abandons deep faith without grief or struggle* | | |

FIX

Show the cost of losing faith. The prayers that no longer comfort. The community that turns away. The hollow feeling where certainty used to be. In *Serpent & Dove*, Reid doesn't simply stop believing. His entire sense of self shatters when he discovers that the Archbishop uses scripture as a tool for punishment rather than salvation, and that he himself is the son of a witch. His crisis is a gradual, agonising process of discovery, not a clean break. Make the choice hard enough that choosing love anyway means something.

The Divine: Gods & Powers

The first thing you have to decide is if there are higher powers in your world and if they are true.

The implications for your romance will be huge. If gods are confirmed and active, then “faith” isn’t really faith anymore - it’s recognition of fact. Characters will not be able to question whether miracles occur when miracles occur all the time. If gods are undetermined or absent, then characters may struggle with whether they believe at all, or if they just obey. And as far as the love story goes, this determines if defying the laws of the divine will result in the anger of a real being who may seek retaliation, or if breaking from tradition has no supernatural enforcement.

How you define your theological structure creates the potential for various types of stories. With multiple gods available, characters can seek patronage from individual gods, use the deities against one another, or serve different masters. A world with one god provides clearer moral stakes but leaves less room for religious diversity.

When you’re writing devout characters, show faith through habit, not declaration. A devout character touches their holy symbol before danger, whispers a prayer when frightened, calls upon the name of their god while taking an oath. As a result of their faith, the way characters view events changes - that timely rescue did not occur by chance, it was providence. You don’t need to explain the theology; let your characters live it. When writing characters of different faiths interacting, let their assumptions collide in small ways. Different words for good fortune. Different gestures of respect. Different things that feel sacred or profane. A person’s faith will become evident in the things they’re unwilling to do, what they’re willing to sacrifice, and what comforts them when everything else fails.

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	STORY IMPLICATIONS
Monotheism	One supreme deity	Clear moral law; heresy feels absolute; questioning the faith means questioning everything
Polytheism	Multiple gods with different domains	Gods can conflict; characters choose patrons; divine politics mirrors mortal politics

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	STORY IMPLICATIONS
Dualism	Two opposing forces (good/evil, order/chaos)	Cosmic war; sides must be chosen; grey areas feel transgressive
Animism	Spirits in nature, ancestors, places	Local sacred sites; honouring the dead; magic tied to specific locations
Confirmed gods	Deities actively manifest and intervene	Faith isn't faith anymore; divine will is knowable
Absent gods	Gods existed once but are gone/silent	Seeking lost divinity; old rituals with uncertain power; hope or despair
Ambiguous	Faith without proof; gods may or may not exist	Room for genuine doubt; faith as choice; religious and secular worldviews can coexist
Atheistic	No gods; religion is cultural/social	Focus on community and tradition; meaning is human-made

Which theological system describes your world, and how does it shape what faith means for your characters?

You can combine types (e.g., polytheism with confirmed gods, or animism with absent gods). Your choice shapes what religious doubt, devotion, and defiance look like in your story.

YOUR ANSWER

Are the Gods Real?

This changes everything. In a world where gods visibly answer prayers, atheism is unreasonable. In a world where they don't, devout faith is a choice, admirable or foolish depending on perspective.

What's the divine reality of your world?

Whether gods are real and active affects how your characters relate to faith and what divine intervention might mean for their romance.

STATUS	WHAT THIS MEANS FOR STORY
Gods actively intervene	Miracles happen; divine will is knowable; characters can appeal directly to deity
Gods exist but are distant	Real but rarely manifest; faith is still faith; characters must act without divine guidance
Gods may or may not exist	Ambiguous; genuine belief and genuine doubt are both reasonable positions
Gods are dead/departed	Once real, now gone; faith is memory and hope; old magic fading
No gods	Religion is human tradition, not supernatural reality; meaning comes from community, not deity

If gods are real, what can they actually do?

Can gods grant magic? Curse people? Speak through prophets? Raise the dead? Appear in person? A god who can directly punish forbidden love creates very different stakes than a god who works through doctrine and social pressure.

YOUR ANSWER

What limits divine power?

Unlimited gods create story problems, because why don't they just fix everything? Can gods do anything, or are they constrained? By each other? By cosmic law? By their own nature? By mortal free will?

YOUR ANSWER

Major Deities & Powers

Deity Domains & Aspects

Use this list for inspiration when creating gods. Pick domains that create story opportunities, especially domains that could bless, forbid, or complicate love.

CATEGORY	POSSIBLE DOMAINS
Nature & Elements	Sun, moon, stars, storms, sea, earth, fire, harvest, seasons, animals, forests, rivers
Life & Death	Birth, fertility, healing, plague, death, the afterlife, ancestors, rebirth, dreams
Human Affairs	Love, marriage, family, war, peace, justice, vengeance, merchants, travellers, thieves
Knowledge & Craft	Wisdom, prophecy, secrets, magic, smithing, weaving, music, poetry, writing, time
Abstract Concepts	Fate, fortune, chaos, order, truth, lies, beauty, boundaries, thresholds, oaths
Emotions & States	Joy, grief, rage, fear, madness, ecstasy, courage, despair, hope, desire

Gods with overlapping domains create pantheon politics. A god of war and a god of death might compete for soldiers' prayers. A god of love and a god of duty create the exact tension your romance needs.

Identify the gods or spiritual forces that exist in your world. Focus on those relevant to your story, because you don't need a complete pantheon, just the ones who matter. Think especially about which god's laws the romance violates, and which god might bless it.

Deity/Power 1:

Describe your world's primary deity: What is their name? What do they govern? What is their personality/nature? What do they demand from followers? What do they offer in return?

YOUR ANSWER

Deity/Power 2:

If your world has an opposing force or antagonist deity: What is their name? What do they govern? What is their nature? What do they demand? What do they offer?

YOUR ANSWER

Deity/Power 3 (if applicable):

Is there a deity specifically relevant to your romance — a god of love, forbidden things, or liminal spaces? Describe their name, domain, personality, demands, and offerings.

YOUR ANSWER

Describe any additional deity important to your story: Name, domain, personality, demands, and offerings.

YOUR ANSWER

How do the gods relate to each other?

Divine politics often mirrors mortal politics. Are they a harmonious pantheon? Competing rivals? Locked in cosmic war? Indifferent to each other? Gods in conflict can take different sides of your romance.

YOUR ANSWER

Magic & Religion

Romantasy typically combines elements of magic and faith into a single system. Magic can be thought of as a gift provided by the gods, but equally, magic can represent heresy which a church will try to eliminate. Wherever the two meet, the world becomes a realm in which the consequences of moral choice are always tangible in their magical impact, and where falling in love can result in loss of magical power, protection, or your place in the divine order.

The reason why this applies to romance specifically is that it changes how rebellion functions from a societal concept to a supernatural one. If losing divine favour means losing magical function, then a character who chooses a forbidden lover does not merely risk being ostracised. They risk losing their magical abilities at the same time they need them the most.

In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou's magic operates on a principle of balance. Each spell costs something. When she uses her power to protect Reid, each spell causes her to lose memories and sensation. Their love literally consumes Lou one spell at a time. The Chasseurs see this as Lou "tempting" Reid; the story clearly shows that what she is doing is the greatest act of selflessness possible.

In *Priory of the Orange Tree*, Ead's siden magic, drawn from the fruit of a sacred orange tree, is branded heresy in the West. She is forced to operate secretly, pretending to be a maid so no one will discover the "heresy" of her magic is what is keeping the Queen alive. The bodyguard-crush dynamic is elevated due to Ead's magic being the very source that could potentially destroy the relationship should it be discovered.

In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy's magical "blessing," the ability to sense others' emotions and pain, is depicted by the state faith as evidence of her divine worth. Once the lie of the predatory vampire "Ascended" gods is exposed and the entire religious system is shown to be built on lies, Poppy's magical abilities become the evidence of the lie. Her romance with Casteel is the catalyst for this theological deconstruction.

How does religion explain magic in your world?

Divine gift? Demonic corruption? Natural force the church claims authority over? Ancient power that predates the current religion? The answer shapes whether your magical character is blessed or damned.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your character's magic come from a divine source?

If magic is a gift from the gods, what happens to that gift when the character defies divine law for love? Does the power weaken, change, or disappear? Or does love itself become a new source of power?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the religion condemn your character's magic?

If the beloved's magic is heresy, then the romance is inherently blasphemous. The character isn't just breaking a rule. They're choosing to love the thing their faith tells them is evil.

YOUR ANSWER

What are the magical consequences of religious defiance?

Loss of power? Transformation? Curse? New and different magic? In systems where faith and magic are linked, choosing love over the gods should have supernatural consequences, not just social ones.

YOUR ANSWER

Quick Reference: Magic & Religion

How does religion relate to magic in your world? How does religion explain magic? Is your character's magic divine, heretical, or something else? What happens to their magic if they defy religious law? How does magic raise the romantic stakes?

YOUR ANSWER

Religious Institutions & Authority

Gods may exist, however, it is institutions that make religion have power. The temple, the church, the priesthood: these are human structures, with human politics, human corruption, and the potential to do either great good or harm. In terms of your romance, institutions are where divine law gets enforced, where vows are administered, where forbidden unions are discovered and punished.

Religious authorities can be allies, enemies, or complex figures caught between doctrine and compassion. They represent the institution, but they're also human beings. The priest who has to enforce a law they privately question. The oracle who sees a prophecy they wish they could unsee. The inquisitor who genuinely believes they're saving souls.

What religious institutions exist?

Focus on institutions that could affect your romance: those that might forbid, bless, or complicate your characters' relationship.

What are the key religious institutions in your world? For each, describe their function, the power they hold, and how they interact with other power structures.

YOUR ANSWER

Who leads religious institutions?

These leaders may become allies or antagonists. Think about who holds power to help or harm your characters' relationship.

POSITION	TITLE	HOW THEY GAIN AUTHORITY	EXAMPLE
Highest authority			The Archbishop: rises through Church hierarchy, appointed by predecessor and council
Local/regional leaders			Bishops: assigned by Archbishop, control regional parishes and hunter corps
Day-to-day clergy			Priests: trained in seminaries, assigned to parishes, conduct daily services

How much power does religious authority have?

The more institutional power religion holds, the higher the stakes when characters defy it. A religion with only spiritual authority creates social consequences; one with military force creates life-or-death ones.

- ☐ Spiritual only (moral authority, influence over believers)
 - ☐ Political influence (advises rulers, shapes law)
 - ☐ Legal authority (religious courts, enforceable doctrine)
 - ☐ Military force (holy warriors, inquisitors, temple guards)
 - ☐ Economic power (controls land, tithes, trade)
 - ☐ Other: _____

How does religious authority relate to political authority?

This shapes what defying religion costs. In a theocracy, religious disobedience is political treason.

When church and state are separate, religious dissent may be socially costly but legally protected.

- ☐ United (theocracy — religious and political authority are one)
- ☐ Allied (separate institutions that support each other)
- ☐ Competing (both claim authority; power struggles between them)
- ☐ Separate (religion has no political power; dissent is a personal matter)
- ☐ Hostile (state actively suppresses or controls religion)

Who becomes clergy/priests/religious figures?

Access to religious authority tells you who can wield it, and who might be trapped by it. If only certain bloodlines become priests, religious power is aristocratic. If anyone can be called, religious power is potentially democratic. Either way, someone your character loves may be bound to serve.

- [illegible]

What does religious life require?

The obligations of religious life create the constraints your characters operate under. Celibacy vows create romantic obstacles. Poverty requirements affect what they can do for loved ones. Separation from secular life means choosing the order means losing the person.

- ☐ Celibacy
 - ☐ Poverty
 - ☐ Specific training or education
 - ☐ Oaths or vows (specify: _____)
 - ☐ Separation from secular life
 - ☐ Other: _____

Is either character part of the religious hierarchy?

Religious roles often carry vows and obligations that directly conflict with romantic love.

If a character holds a religious position: What is it? What vows or obligations bind them? What would they lose by leaving?

YOUR ANSWER

Does religious authority oppose or support the relationship?

Who specifically? What will they do about it? Are there authorities who might secretly help?

YOUR ANSWER

Religious Law, Doctrine & Forbidden Love

What are the actual restrictions of faith on love and marriage? Faith takes what was once an abstract idea and makes it a very real barrier. At this point, the will of God has turned into the law that prohibits your character from doing something, or requires them to do something.

This is probably the most romantic way that religious law can be used in a romantasy. The protagonists' love isn't just prohibited by religious law, but is considered heresy, or blasphemous, or an existential threat to their world. In *Serpent & Dove*, the Church views Lou as a "monster" inherently. In *From Blood and Ash*, the state religion deifies Poppy and isolates her completely. In *The Jasmine Throne*, the faith of the empire requires all female nobility to burn alive for "purity." These are not minor prohibitions. They are the systems by which society operates, and so the couple's romance feels like a rebellion against the universe.

What does your religion teach about love and marriage?

Sacred gift? Duty? Path to the divine? Distraction from spiritual purpose? How a religion frames love determines whether your characters' feelings are blessed or blasphemous.

YOUR ANSWER

What does religious law say about who can marry whom?

Restrictions based on faith, role, gender, species, class?

YOUR ANSWER

What religious restrictions specifically affect your characters' relationship?

Identify the specific rules that create obstacles. These become the stakes your characters must navigate.

- ☐ Forbidden to marry outside the faith
 - ☐ Celibacy required for certain roles
 - ☐ Must marry within specific group
 - ☐ Specific intimacy prohibitions
 - ☐ One character serves a deity that forbids attachment
 - ☐ The beloved's magic/nature is classified as heretical
 - ☐ Other: _____

What are the consequences for violating religious law?

Not just social disapproval. What are the spiritual, magical, and institutional consequences? Excommunication? Damnation? Loss of divine favour or magic? Ritual punishment? Social ostracism?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character prioritise religious law over their own desires?

Which one, and why? What would it take for them to choose love over religious duty? This character creates the most interesting tension: the one who genuinely believes the law is right even as they fall in love.

YOUR ANSWER

The Heretic Love Interest

There is a big distinction in the way the audience experiences a religiously forbidden romantic involvement, versus a romantic involvement with someone who is specifically condemned by the religion. A behavioural taboo (breaking celibacy, marrying outside the faith, violating a vow) is where you're doing something wrong, but there's nothing wrong with the person you've done something wrong with. You have options such as making amends, finding a loophole, or redefining the relationship through marriage or dispensation.

A heretic love interest romance, however, is a whole other ball game. The person you're in love with is the problem. Demon. Witch. Fae. "Dark One." Hated bloodline. The act of loving such a person does not simply jeopardise the individual's standing in society - it challenges their very moral identity, as well as the metaphysical order of the community in which they live. We are not dealing with behavioural prohibitions here, but rather ontological taboos, and the type of resolution required will be very different.

One reason why this type of romance is so effective is that it creates an epistemological crisis for the protagonist. The idea that "they are monsters" that has been ingrained in them since birth is constantly challenged by the embodied intimacy of the romance ("yet I desire, I trust, I know this person"). The internal conflict is not simply one or two scenes of temptation. Instead, it is a continued debate within the protagonist about whose authority should be followed - the doctrine of their religion (the priests, the vows, the myths of the community) or their own first-person knowledge (their senses, thoughts, what they see with their own eyes).

Feyre's fear of the Fae in *ACOTAR* acts as a displaced sacred order. When she sees the Other that she fears, she instinctually reaches for prayer, even though she believes that "mortals do not keep gods to worship anymore." Feyre's journey is one of "unlearning" as she moves from inherited certainty to situational judgement. Casteel, in *From Blood and Ash*, is the "Dark One" of Poppy's mythological universe; he is the personification of everything that Poppy's religion was created to fight against. Poppy's desire for him is portrayed as a problem of doctrine: she feels "unworthy by the gods." Reid, in *Serpent & Dove*, does not have a primary conflict of "I want sex but my rules forbid it." Rather, his primary conflict is "the woman I desire is defined by the system I identify with as nonhuman." The romance threatens collapse not of chastity but of ontology.

How It Differs from Rule-Breaking

ASPECT	BEHAVIOURAL TABOO (RULE-BREAKING)	ONTOLOGICAL TABOO (HERETIC LOVE INTEREST)
What's forbidden	The <i>action</i> (marrying, touching, loving)	The beloved's <i>nature</i> (species, magic, bloodline)
What's at stake	Social standing, religious punishment	The protagonist's entire moral identity and worldview
What resolution requires	Repentance, loophole, dispensation	Reclassifying what counts as "evil," or leaving the faith entirely
Scope of repair	Can end with private compromise	Demands public stakes: exposure of institutional violence, reframing of history

The Belief Change Arc

When your protagonist falls for a "heretic," their belief shifts through a recognisable progression. Understanding these stages helps you pace the internal conflict so it doesn't read as superficial or cheap. The author of *Serpent & Dove* has described this as the central craft challenge of writing Reid's arc: making his de-indoctrination believable within romance beats.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Doctrinal certainty	The protagonist fully believes what they've been taught. The beloved's kind are monsters, demons, evil by nature.	Safety. The world makes sense. Categories are clear.
Embodied contradiction	Attraction, proximity, or intimacy creates sensory counter-evidence that doesn't fit the doctrine.	Confusion. The doctrine says one thing; the body and heart say another.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
Epistemic crisis	A revelation forces the protagonist to question not just this relationship but everything they've been taught.	Vertigo. If this was a lie, what else was? The ground dissolves.
Reclassification	The protagonist revises their moral categories, either by redeeming the beloved or redefining what "evil" means.	Loss and liberation. The old world is gone. A new one must be built.

Map your protagonist's belief change arc.

If your love interest is a heretic beloved, use the four stages above to trace how your protagonist's certainty fractures. What breaks first? What holds longest?

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS IN YOUR STORY	THE SCENE OR MOMENT
<i>Doctrinal certainty — what do they believe at the start?</i>	<i>Reid believes all witches are monsters. His identity as a Chasseur depends on it.</i>	<i>His oath-taking ceremony; his first kill</i>
Doctrinal certainty — what do they believe at the start?		
Embodied contradiction — when does attraction first conflict with doctrine?		

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS IN YOUR STORY	THE SCENE OR MOMENT
Epistemic crisis — what revelation shatters their certainty?		
Reclassification — how do they rebuild their moral categories?		

Resolution: Redemption or Redefinition?

Your heretical love interest story can follow either of these paths. Which path you are writing will define the direction your story takes.

The Redemption Path: The condemned beloved is purified, converted, cured, or revealed as uniquely exception-worthy. The protagonist’s original moral map stays largely intact. The couple is re-admitted to the moral community. A great way to go about it if the story is looking to demonstrate that the faith is generally correct, but simply made a mistake regarding this particular circumstance.

The Redefinition Path: The doctrine itself is exposed as partial, weaponised, or wrong. “Evil” is redefined and generally pointed at the institution or government which labelled people as “evil.” The couple becomes the warrant for a new moral order built on lived experience rather than inherited dogma. This is the dominant pathway in contemporary romantasy. In *ACOTAR*, the fae stop being seen as inherently evil; “evil” relocates to systems of domination. In *From Blood and Ash*, the “holy” Ascended order is exposed as predatory; the “Dark One” is reclassified from demon to political subject. In *Serpent & Dove*, the story redeems Reid (the doctrinal subject) rather than Lou (the condemned beloved). Lou doesn’t get cleansed back to “acceptable”; instead, Reid is forced to acknowledge that some magic is protective and some “monsters” are produced by persecution.

Which pathway is your story on?

If the love interest is condemned by their nature (not just their actions): What does the protagonist’s faith say they are? What does experience reveal them to be? Does the story

redeem the beloved or redefine the faith? What is the moment the protagonist's certainty fractures? What replaces the old moral categories?

YOUR ANSWER

Personal Faith & Hidden Devotion

There are many ways people believe in religion. They may have strong faith in their gods, but hate the way the priests run things. Others may just go through the motions to fit in. Which type of believer someone is can greatly impact how the romance develops. If the devout believer does something against the rules of the religion, they may lose the favour of their god. On the other hand, the cultural believer risks loss of connection to their community, and ultimately their sense of identity, but not their soul.

But when a person has to keep their faith a secret, the dynamics of the romance take on a whole different light. The witch pretending to be a devoted member of the church. The priestess pretending to be a chambermaid. The heretic disguising their true feelings as orthodoxy. Both parties share the vulnerability of being truly known, the peril of being discovered, and the intensely intimate experience of sharing a secret which could cost one another their lives.

This is why this plot device is so powerful - the positioning. In the most effective cases, the person with a hidden faith falls in love with someone working for the same group that would kill them if the truth came out. Reid is a Captain of the Chasseurs, witch-hunters whose motto is “thou shalt not suffer a witch to live.” Ravyn Yew in *One Dark Window* is Captain of the Destriers, tasked with hunting down those with magical abilities. Gaspar in *The Wolf and the Woodsman* is a prince of a fanatical kingdom. The romance becomes a high-stakes game of cat and mouse. The closer two people get to each other, the greater the danger becomes, because closeness requires lowering the very shields that ensure survival.

The emotional toll of living in fear of being discovered is a kind of soul ache: a state of perpetual hyper-vigilance where every moment of tenderness is shadowed by the knowledge that discovery means death. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou’s magic gives off a distinct scent that can warn sensitive observers of its presence. Proximity itself is a threat to the secret. In *One Dark Window*, Elspeth hides a spirit called the Nightmare in her mind, a monster that could emerge during moments of vulnerability or passion, making intimacy

Here’s the paradox, though: secrecy can deepen intimacy rather than hinder it. When the truth is finally shared, the act of revealing a forbidden faith becomes a shared ritual between the lovers, a moment of “shared sacrilege” that binds them. In *The Jasmine Throne*, the waterfall scene where Malini witnesses Priya’s true nature transforms their dynamic from servant-princess to allies in rebellion. In *Serpent & Dove*, the revelation that Reid himself possesses magic (he’s the first male witch) creates a new form of intimacy built on mutual exile rather than deception.

MECHANISM	HOW IT WORKS	IMPACT ON THE ROMANCE
Sensory masking	Magic has physical tells, a smell, a glow, a temperature shift, that must be suppressed during closeness	Proximity itself threatens the secret; every intimate moment is a near-miss
Class disguise	The practitioner hides as a servant, commoner, or anonymous figure	A class barrier to romance that only breaks when the “true nature” is revealed
The monster within	A spirit, possession, or transformation that must be suppressed during vulnerability	The hidden nature is a literal danger to the lover; intimacy risks unleashing it
Heritage obfuscation	The character hides their ancestry, bloodline, or cultural identity	Discovery threatens not just the individual but the community they’re protecting
Performative orthodoxy	The practitioner performs the dominant religion’s rituals while secretly practising their own	Every public prayer is a lie; the gap between performance and truth widens with every day

The Revelation Moment

The moment of revelation is one of the most charged scenes in any hidden-faith romance. It typically functions as the crisis point, the black moment where everything the character feared comes true. How the lover reacts determines whether the romance survives.

REVELATION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLE
The crisis of betrayal	The lover feels deceived; their faith and their love are both shattered simultaneously	In <i>Serpent & Dove</i> , Reid’s reaction is rage followed by conflicted hurt; the person he loved and the institution

REVELATION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	EXAMPLE
		he served are both revealed as lies
The transactional realignment	The lover immediately sees the strategic value of the secret; intimacy shifts from personal to political	In <i>The Jasmine Throne</i> , Malini recognises Priya's magic as useful and their dynamic shifts from servant-princess to unlikely allies
Shared exile	Both characters discover they're outcasts from their respective worlds; the secret creates mutual understanding	In <i>The Wolf and the Woodsman</i> , Évike's magic and Gáspár's questioning of his own faith leads to a tenuous pact; their mutual loathing turns to affection because they're both now exiles
The sacrifice reveal	The hidden practitioner uses forbidden magic to save the lover, outing themselves but proving their nature isn't evil	The ultimate "proof of love": the practitioner risks everything to protect the person who should be their enemy

The "remedy" for the betrayal is often a moment of self-sacrifice. The hidden practitioner must use their forbidden magic to save the lover, thereby outing themselves but proving that their nature isn't monstrous. This transforms the revelation from a source of conflict into a proof of love.

What does your protagonist actually believe?

Not what they're supposed to believe. What do they genuinely feel about the divine? Deep faith? Doubt? Going through motions? Complicated relationship with their gods?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your love interest actually believe?

Deep faith? Doubt? Going through motions? Complicated relationship with their gods? Their genuine beliefs may align with or differ from your protagonist's, creating harmony or another layer of conflict.

YOUR ANSWER

How does each character's personal faith differ from official doctrine?

The gap between personal belief and institutional religion creates room for characters to redefine faith rather than abandon it.

For each character, where do they agree with their faith's doctrine and where do they disagree?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character follow religious practice without genuine belief?

Why? Social expectation? Family pressure? Fear? Habit? Hoping belief will come?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character have genuine faith but reject religious authority?

Do they believe in the gods but distrust priests? Follow their own interpretation? This creates the possibility of redefining faith rather than abandoning it.

YOUR ANSWER

How does personal faith affect how they approach religious obstacles?

A character with deep, genuine faith faces an existential crisis when they defy religious law — they're not just breaking rules, they're betraying who they are. A character who follows religion out of habit or social pressure faces a different kind of loss: community and identity rather than spiritual anguish. Knowing which type of believer your character is shapes the entire emotional texture of their struggle.

YOUR ANSWER

Is either character hiding their true faith or spiritual identity?

Hidden faith creates unique romantic tension. The lover who discovers the secret must choose: accept the truth, or become the instrument of the beloved's destruction.

If a character hides their faith or identity: What are they concealing? How do they conceal it? What would discovery cost? Is the love interest an agent of the persecuting institution? How is the truth revealed? Which revelation type plays out? How does it change the relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Daily Practice & Devotion

Religion is much more than institutions and doctrines. It's all of those daily actions, those moments that shape the way in which people believe. Once you understand what religion looks like in the everyday life of your character, you can write them with a true sense of devotion or as someone who has lost their way from their faith. And for romance, daily practice is where faith becomes visible: the prayer whispered before danger, the ritual skipped after a forbidden kiss, the holy symbol tucked away when entering the lover's bed.

What religious practices are part of daily life?

Daily practices make faith feel real on the page. What rituals would your characters perform automatically, or deliberately skip?

PRACTICE	WHEN/HOW OFTEN	WHAT IT INVOLVES	WHICH CHARACTERS OBSERVE IT
Morning observance	At sunrise, facing east	Touch the heart and lips, whisper a prayer of gratitude	

PRACTICE	WHEN/HOW OFTEN	WHAT IT INVOLVES	WHICH CHARACTERS OBSERVE IT
Meal rituals	Before the first bite	Leave a small portion aside for the ancestors	
Evening observance			
Weekly/regular gatherings			

What religious objects or symbols do people wear or keep?

Amulets? Sacred texts? Prayer beads? Holy symbols? These details make faith tangible, and they create charged moments when a character removes them, hides them, or clutches them during temptation.

YOUR ANSWER

What phrases, blessings, or invocations are common in speech?

Religious language in everyday speech shows how deeply faith permeates culture. “God willing,” “bless you,” “by the saints.” These phrases also reveal when a character is losing faith, because they stop saying them.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there practices they've stopped observing? Started observing? Hidden from others?

Changes in practice often signal changes in faith. The character who stops praying after tragedy. The one who secretly visits forbidden shrines. The one who prays harder after a guilty kiss.

YOUR ANSWER

What comfort does faith provide?

In fear, grief, or uncertainty, what does religion offer that nothing else does? Understanding this shows what they'd lose by leaving.

YOUR ANSWER

What does it feel like when they pray or practise their faith?

Connection? Comfort? Obligation? Silence? Doubt? Peace? This is faith as experience, not just belief.

YOUR ANSWER

How might falling in love change their religious practice?

Do they pray about it? Feel guilty during rituals? Find new meaning in old prayers? Stop practising? Start practising?

YOUR ANSWER

Crisis of Faith

A person's faith can break when their beliefs clash with their feelings. That is one of the greatest internal struggles you can have in your writing. It goes beyond "should I break this rule?" It goes down to "is everything I believed a lie?"

A crisis of faith is an unsettling feeling. To a person who truly believes, faith has always been the framework that gives purpose to their life and explains why certain events occur, the meaning of existence, and who they are. Once that framework crumbles, so does every other part of the structure. The crisis often starts with a question that won't go away. Why would a loving God prevent this love? Sometimes you'll find an answer that satisfies you. Other times you'll find that the answer rings hollow and weakens the foundation even more.

Reid's crisis of faith in *Serpent & Dove* is a process of degradation. As a "blade of the Church," he has built his entire identity around the concept that witches are irredeemable monsters. His arranged marriage to Lou, a secret witch, is the first step into a long process of a "soul ache" as his experiences contrast with the teachings he received from the Church. The realization that the Archbishop uses scripture to punish instead of to save, and that Reid is actually the son of a witch, destroys the black-and-white world of purity his faith was built on. He is the very thing he was raised to kill.

Poppy's crisis of faith in *From Blood and Ash* is a complete destruction. She learns that the gods she has been raised to worship do not exist and the "Ascended" are predators that feed on the people they say they protect. Her crisis of faith ultimately ends with her proving the entire system is a house of cards, however, she loses everything she had believed about herself in the process.

You want to create a crisis of faith as a process. You want to depict the character experiencing several stages: attempting to hold onto their faith stronger, becoming angry at their god, making deals for exceptions, mourning the loss of what they believed in. Allow them to try the old comforts - prayer, ritual, sacred texts - and demonstrate how these efforts work less and less well, or differently than before. Portray the physical sensations of faith crisis: the hollow feeling where certainty used to be, the vertigo of having no ground, the loneliness of losing something that connected them to community and meaning. If faith is rebuilt, show it as something different than before. Scarred, harder-won, more honest. The crisis isn't resolved by finding the right argument; it's resolved by learning to live without certainty, or by finding a different kind of faith entirely.

Does the relationship cause either character to question their faith?

What specifically do they question? The existence of gods? The rightness of doctrine? The authority of religious leaders? The goodness of a god who forbids love? ⁴⁶

What would it mean for them to lose their faith?

Not just leaving a religion. Losing the belief itself. What would that cost? What would fill the void?

YOUR ANSWER

Do they try to reconcile their faith with their feelings?

How? Reinterpreting doctrine? Finding loopholes? Believing the gods would understand?
Distinguishing between divine will and institutional corruption?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment when faith breaks, or is renewed?

The crisis point when they must choose, or when they find a new understanding:

YOUR ANSWER

Can they find a version of faith that includes their love?

Is there a way to believe that doesn't require giving up the relationship? This is the "redefining faith" resolution, harder than leaving, sometimes more satisfying.

YOUR ANSWER

How Religious Obstacles Resolve

Crisis is the setup. Resolution is the payoff. It's how your characters deal with the conflict between faith and love which will give you the sense of whether the ending has been earned or if it's come about by accident, and whether your characters' romance carries weight beyond the final page.

In my experience the best resolutions are those where the characters have paid some sort of real cost. When the characters pay a price for their love - magic, community, self-identity - then the reconciliation of faith and love has value. Convenient resolutions are often the result of last-minute revelations, or shifts in power that remove all obstacles, as opposed to the characters having to work through them.

A recurring distinction in published romantasy is the difference between rejecting the institution and rejecting the faith. In *Serpent & Dove* and *Priory of the Orange Tree*, the characters don't become atheists. They reject leaders who twisted the faith for power. In *From Blood and Ash* and *The Jasmine Throne*, the institution and the faith are so entangled that the only resolution is to burn the entire system down.

Resolution Patterns

RESOLUTION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT MAKES IT EARNED	WHAT MAKES IT CONVENIENT
Redefinition	Stripping away institutional lies to build a syncretic or reformed faith	Requires a painful identity crisis; the character must lose their old self before finding a new understanding	The global peace that follows feels too easy; centuries of conflict resolved in a chapter
Humanisation	Gradual erosion of dogma through proximity and lived experience with the "enemy"	Slow pacing mirrors realistic psychological change; no single revelation fixes everything	The character was "never really that devout anyway," nullifying the conflict

RESOLUTION TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT MAKES IT EARNED	WHAT MAKES IT CONVENIENT
Deconstruction	Proving the religion is a fraud; the entire system is exposed as lies	Works when the character's trauma and isolation justify the rebellion	The character becomes a god themselves, replacing one divine authority with another
The Loophole	Fulfilling the letter of the law while subverting its intent	Carries heavy personal cost (lifeforce, sacrifice, permanent loss)	The loophole is convenient and costs nothing
Divine Blessing	A god intervenes to reward sacrifice or fulfil a promise	The blessing responds to a genuine act of selflessness or martyrdom	The blessing arrives unearned, a deus ex machina
Rebellion	Embracing the "monstrous" label and overthrowing the religious state	Politically earned through sacrifice and strategy	The romance feels like strategic alliance rather than genuine love

How does the religious obstacle resolve in your story?

Which pattern are you using? What does your character lose in the process? The cost is what makes the resolution feel real.

How does the religious conflict resolve? Which resolution pattern do you use? What does the character lose or sacrifice? Do they reject the institution, the faith, or both? What replaces the old belief system? Does it feel earned — and why?

YOUR ANSWER

Stress-test your resolution.

Using the “earned vs. convenient” columns in the reference table above, honestly assess: does your resolution cost enough? Or does it arrive too easily?

Test whether your resolution is earned: What does your character permanently lose? Could the obstacle have been removed without sacrifice? Does the resolution change who they are, or just what they’re allowed to do?

YOUR ANSWER

Sin, Virtue & Religious Guilt

Religious shame operates differently than social shame. It's not just about what others think. It's about what you believe you fundamentally are.

When we say "I did something forbidden," there is action involved and so, in theory, there is the possibility for redemptive action. When we say "I am something wrong," we are talking about our very identity, and no amount of repentance can change your nature. In *Serpent & Dove*, Reid's guilt isn't just "I broke a rule." It's "I loved a witch. What does that make me?" Once Reid discovers he is the son of a witch, the line between the sinner and the sin is completely erased.

Religious guilt follows you into private moments. It can even make love itself feel like proof of sinfulness: If I were good, I wouldn't want this. The fact that I want it shows what I am.

What does your religion teach about desire and love?

Sacred gift? Dangerous temptation? Test of faith? How the religion frames desire shapes whether characters feel blessed or damned by their own feelings.

YOUR ANSWER

What romantic or sexual behaviours are considered sinful?

Understanding what's forbidden helps you write the internal conflict of characters who believe they're doing wrong.

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character feel they're sinning by being in this relationship?

What specifically triggers the guilt: the act of loving, or the identity of the person they love?

Does either character feel sinful for their desire? Which character, why do they feel that way, and how (if ever) do they reconcile faith and desire?

YOUR ANSWER

Does religious shame affect how they behave in the relationship?

Withdrawal? Self-punishment? Trying to resist feelings? Guilt after intimacy?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it take to release religious shame?

Reinterpretation? Leaving the faith? Divine reassurance? Accepting love isn't sin? Building a new moral framework?

YOUR ANSWER

Sacred Time & Calendar

Religion governs time. Holy days, sacred seasons, periods of fasting or celebration: these rhythms structure the year and create occasions where religious expectations are heightened. For romance, sacred time can both separate lovers (forbidden times) and bring them together (festivals that relax normal rules).

What major holy days and sacred seasons exist?

Holy days and sacred seasons create story opportunities: festivals where rules relax, sacred days when forbidden love feels more transgressive, forbidden times that separate lovers, and rituals that bring characters together. Focus on the ones that could affect your romance.

Describe a key holy day or sacred time in your world: When is it? What does it celebrate? How is it observed? What is forbidden during this time? What romantic opportunity does it create?

YOUR ANSWER

How do these timing restrictions affect your characters?

Must they wait for a specific time? Are they separated during a religious season? Do they violate sacred time to be together, and what does that cost?

YOUR ANSWER

How do people mark sacred vs. ordinary time or space?

Thresholds between sacred and ordinary create charged moments. What changes when your characters cross into holy ground or holy time?

YOUR ANSWER

Sacred Spaces

Sacred spaces have a unique sense of authority in the world of love. They're places where the transcendent and the taboo converge. Meeting in a temple. Finding time for each other in a sanctuary. Getting blessed at a shrine.

You should write your sacred space to be distinguishable from the moment of entry. The stillness. The scent of incense or old stone. How sound acts in a different way than anywhere else. Show how your characters adjust their behaviour unconsciously: speak softer, take slower steps, become physically smaller or more cautious. Let the space dictate rules without either of the characters stating them; the devout character will know to genuflect, the outsider watches and walks a step behind. Allow the physical aspects of the space (candlelight, echoes of footsteps, cold stone) to build an atmosphere that emphasises the emotional rhythm of the scene. Speaking a confession in a temple where lying becomes impossible. Touching in a space where the act feels even more transgressive. A sanctuary where both characters are under the watchful eye of the god.

What sacred locations exist?

Sacred spaces can serve as sanctuary, meeting place, or site of spiritual reckoning for your characters.

What sacred spaces exist in your world — temples, shrines, natural sacred sites, pilgrimage destinations, forbidden holy places? Describe them and who is allowed to enter.

YOUR ANSWER

What makes a space sacred?

What makes a space sacred determines what it means when your characters enter — or defile — that space. A temple consecrated by divine presence carries different weight than a grove made holy by history.

YOUR ANSWER

Does a sacred site play a role in your romance?

Do they meet there? Seek blessing? Take sanctuary? Perform a forbidden ritual?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there places where certain relationships are blessed, or cursed?

Sacred ground where vows are binding? Temples where certain unions are forbidden?

YOUR ANSWER

Ritual & Ceremony

Religious rituals are among the most emotionally charged scenes in romantasy and the most structurally potent. Weddings, funerals, vow-taking ceremonies, initiation rites, fertility festivals. The most important thing to understand about religious rituals in romantasy is that they are NOT just pretty decorations. They're the sites where obligation and desire get twisted together, where a person's personal feelings are turned into public property, and where characters are forced across thresholds they can't uncross.

There are three ways rituals work in romantic novels. Firstly, **restraint as fuel**: the rigid formality of a ceremony produces tension through what hasn't been said or done. The slight touch of hands at a wedding altar has a greater impact on the couple's relationship than a kiss would have had under less formal circumstances. Second, **ritual as transition**: ceremonies force characters across identity thresholds. The Ascension, the Great Rite, the taking of vows - these are all points of no return where the character leaves behind who they were and emerges as someone new. Third, **public stakes**: rituals are performed publicly, and therefore they turn private struggles into public ones. The embarrassment of having a wedding fail or having a secret exposed to everyone present creates the illusion of impossibility for a happy ending. It is this sense of impossibility that causes the readers to want to continue reading.

Ritual Types & Romantic Function

RITUAL TYPE	HOW IT CREATES ROMANTIC TENSION	EXAMPLE
The wrong wedding	The ceremony forces a union with the wrong person, or the ritual structure traps characters in impossible circumstances	In <i>Bridgerton</i> S2, Anthony's wedding to Edwina collapses when his eyes lock onto Kate at the altar; the broken ritual is more powerful than a completed one would have been

RITUAL TYPE	HOW IT CREATES ROMANTIC TENSION	EXAMPLE
The forced marriage	A marriage of necessity becomes a crucible for genuine feeling	In <i>Serpent & Dove</i> , the forced marriage between Lou and Reid, a witch and a witch-hunter, creates a “gilded cage” where proximity slowly erodes dogma
The initiation/ascension	A coming-of-age rite reveals a truth that transforms everything	In <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , the “Ascension” is revealed to be not a divine blessing but a predatory transformation; Poppy choosing intimacy with Hawke before the ceremony is her first act of personal autonomy
The fertility rite	A sacred ceremony exposes hidden desire or forces characters to confront their animal nature	In ACOTAR, the Calanmai ceremony forces Feyre to witness Tamlin’s “beastly” side; later subverted when Feyre and Rhysand generate their own magic on the same night, proving the mating bond is more sacred than the state ritual
The funeral/death rite	Grief strips away all pretence, and love is revealed or confessed in the space the dead have left	The ritual of mourning provides structure for emotional revelation; love discovered or confessed

RITUAL TYPE	HOW IT CREATES ROMANTIC TENSION	EXAMPLE
		when loss makes concealment impossible
The broken vow	A character who has sworn an oath, celibacy, service, silence, breaks it for love	The breaking of a sacred vow is a point of no return that validates the romance as cosmic; in <i>His Secret Illuminations</i> , a monk told he'd lose his powers if he had a lustful thought must choose between his spiritual identity and the person he loves

Completed rituals and broken rituals serve two very different functions in terms of narrative. Completed rituals (the forced marriage that turns into a true love) build long-term tension within the story's structural framework. Broken rituals (the wrong wedding that falls apart) create explosive turning points in the story. Both types of rituals are effective, however, the broken ritual is generally more emotionally impactful because it violates the reader's expectations of formal closure.

Does a religious ritual play a pivotal role in your romance?

Think about weddings, initiations, vow-taking ceremonies, funerals, fertility rites; any structured ceremonial moment that could serve as a turning point.

Describe a key ritual in your story: Which ritual is it? What is it supposed to accomplish? What actually happens? Is it completed or broken? How does it change the relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Does a character undergo a transformation through ritual?

Initiations, ascensions, species changes: these are identity thresholds. What does the character become, and what do they lose?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a ceremony where private feelings become public?

The most charged ritual scenes are those where an audience is watching. What happens when the mask slips in front of the congregation?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your key ritual create romantic tension?

Rituals work through restraint (formality makes small gestures explosive), transition (the character crosses an identity threshold), and public stakes (private feelings become everyone's business). Most powerful rituals use at least two of these.

FUNCTION	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR RITUAL	THE SPECIFIC MOMENT
<i>Restraint as fuel — what can't they do or say during the ceremony?</i>	<i>At the forced marriage, Lou can't reveal she's a witch. The wedding vows are a lie she has to speak in front of the entire Church.</i>	<i>The moment their hands touch during the vow — the only permitted contact, and it has to carry everything they can't say</i>
Restraint as fuel — what can't they do or say during the ceremony?		
Ritual as transition — what does the character become, and what do they lose?		

FUNCTION	HOW IT WORKS IN YOUR RITUAL	THE SPECIFIC MOMENT
Public stakes — who's watching, and what happens if the mask slips?		

Is your key ritual completed or broken? Why?

Completed rituals (the forced marriage that becomes real) build slow-burn tension. Broken rituals (the wedding that falls apart) create explosive turning points. Either works, but know which you're writing and why.

YOUR ANSWER

Religious Community & Belonging

Religious communities give individuals their sense of belonging, their identity as members of a group, their source of support from others, and a social structure to organise their lives. When someone leaves or is rejected by a religious group, they lose every single one of those things.

What distinguishes religious communities from other types of social networks is how comprehensive many of them are. They are the people you celebrate holidays with, the people who help you when your parent dies, the people where you make your close friends. So when someone leaves or is rejected by this community, they don't just lose the opportunity to participate in social activities - they lose an entire way of life.

So instead of asking "what does their religion forbid?" ask "what would they lose if they left?" In many cases, it is not simply a matter of losing their faith.

What religious community do your characters belong to?

Community is often what people lose first when they defy religious rules. What support, identity, and belonging would they sacrifice?

What religious community does each character belong to, and what does it provide them (identity, safety, purpose, belonging)?

YOUR ANSWER

What else does religious community provide that they'd lose?

Social support? Identity? Safety? Business connections? Marriage prospects? Meaning? Purpose? The more comprehensive the community, the more devastating the loss.

What would each character lose if cast out of their religious community?

Not just spiritual consequences. Social, practical, relational losses:

What would each character lose by leaving their religious community?

YOUR ANSWER

Is their family's acceptance tied to religious conformity?

Would religious violation mean losing family as well as faith community? This multiplies the stakes enormously.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there people in their religious community who might support them despite doctrine?

The secret ally who believes love matters more than rules? The reformer who thinks doctrine should change?

YOUR ANSWER

The Afterlife & Sacrifice

The way we think about death affects every part of our lives; it shapes our fears, and it can lead us to do things we would never have done before. Characters who believe in reunion after death approach sacrifice differently than those who believe death is final. And for romance, afterlife beliefs determine whether dying for love feels like ending or beginning, and whether loving the wrong person means eternal damnation or eternal separation.

What do people believe happens after death?

Afterlife beliefs shape how characters think about sacrifice, loss, and whether lovers can be reunited after death.

What does your world's religion teach about the afterlife? What happens to the soul/spirit? Is there judgement, and based on what? What's the good outcome and bad outcome? Can the living affect the dead's fate?

YOUR ANSWER

Are these beliefs literally true in your world?

If the afterlife is confirmed and knowable, dying for love becomes a different calculation. If it's uncertain, faith in reunion after death is poignant hope, not guaranteed promise.

YOUR ANSWER

How do afterlife beliefs affect behaviour?

What do people do (or avoid) because of afterlife consequences?

YOUR ANSWER

Can lovers be reunited after death?

Or does death separate them? Are only certain unions blessed in the afterlife?

YOUR ANSWER

If one character is willing to die, what do they believe happens next?

Their afterlife beliefs shape whether dying for love feels like ending or beginning, loss or reunion.

YOUR ANSWER

Does belief in the afterlife make sacrifice easier or harder?

If they believe in reunion after death, does that make dying for love more tempting? Or does uncertainty make sacrifice more costly?

YOUR ANSWER

Does their relationship affect their afterlife fate?

Does loving the “wrong” person damn them? Does true love grant salvation?

YOUR ANSWER

Mythology, Prophecy & Destiny

Every religion has its founding stories. The tales that explain how things came to be and how people should live. These stories shape how believers understand love, duty, sacrifice, and transgression. And prophecy adds the ultimate layer: are they fated to be together, or fated to destroy each other? If fate has decided, does their choice even matter?

Sacred Stories

Sacred stories serve as models for romance: the tales your characters want to emulate, flee from, or tear down. In *Priory of the Orange Tree*, the founding myth of Saint Galian is simply a male-fabricated myth. It tells us Galian killed the Nameless One and married a princess, when actually it was the woman he claimed to have saved who killed the monster and Galian was a coward. The entire life of Sabran, and her oppression due to her “mandated motherhood,” has been built upon this lie. Once the myth is destroyed, so too is the oppressive religious system that held her captive, and then romance can occur.

Romance and sacred stories use similar mechanics because many times characters define themselves and their relationships using the mythology surrounding their lives. If a character grew up hearing the tale of two gods that gave up everything for each other, they may attempt to replicate that type of relationship. Conversely, a character who has heard the cautionary tale of a god who was punished for loving a mortal may fear becoming that legend. It’s not simply, what are the myths? It’s also which myth do you think your character believes they’re living?

What’s the creation story?

How did the world/gods/people come to exist?

YOUR ANSWER

What are the major sacred stories everyone knows?

These stories create templates for how characters understand their own lives. Do any parallel your romance?

What founding myths or sacred stories exist in your world? For the most important one, what is it about, what does it teach, and how does it parallel your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there stories specifically about love, marriage, or relationships?

Divine lovers? Cautionary tales? Blessed unions? These stories create templates. Characters may try to live up to them or fear becoming cautionary tales themselves.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a founding myth that your romance dismantles or fulfils?

The most powerful sacred stories in romantasy are the ones the plot proves wrong, or proves true in an unexpected way.

YOUR ANSWER

Prophecy & Destiny

Prophecy generates the maximum amount of drama: are they destined to be together, or destined to destroy each other? And if destiny has already made up its mind, does their choice even matter?

The power of prophecy lies in how characters receive it. Take your time revealing the prophecy: the way the speaker says it, the tone of their voice, the exact words used (a prophecy should sound different than everyday language: rhythmic, old-fashioned, unclear). Show the listener physically reacting to the meaning as it sinks in. Once the prophecy is revealed, show both characters fixating on the wording, looking for loopholes, and analysing their own interpretations of what it said. Prophecy creates dramatic irony - the reader can see the implications that the characters are missing, or vice versa. You can use asymmetrical knowledge to create an interesting dynamic: one character knows a prophecy about their relationship and the other doesn't, and the character must decide whether or not to tell them. The prophecy's shadow will weigh heavily on their decisions: is this feeling I'm having based on reality, or am I just fulfilling what was prophesied?

Do prophecies exist in your world?

Prophecy adds a layer of fate vs. choice to your romance. Characters may resist destiny or embrace it.

YOUR ANSWER

If yes:

How do prophecies work?

Divine revelation? Oracle visions? Ancient texts? Prophetic dreams? Astrological calculation?

YOUR ANSWER

Are prophecies always true, sometimes true, or open to interpretation?

This determines how much weight prophecy carries. Infallible prophecy is destiny. Fallible prophecy is guidance that might be wrong. Make prophecies specific enough to create real expectations: “The child of two worlds will unite or destroy” creates tension. “Something important will happen” doesn’t.

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a prophecy about your characters or their relationship?

Prophecies about the romance itself create unique tension around whether love is chosen or fated.

If yes:

What does the prophecy say?

Write the actual prophecy or its key elements:

YOUR ANSWER

Who knows about this prophecy?

Everyone? Select few? Only one character? The asymmetry of knowledge creates tension.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the prophecy suggest they're fated to be together or fated to be apart?

Either direction creates tension. Fated together: is the love real? Fated apart: can they defy destiny?

YOUR ANSWER

How does each character react to the prophecy?

Characters may embrace, resist, deny, or be torn about what prophecy means for them.

If there's a prophecy in your story, how does each character react to it?

YOUR ANSWER

The Prophecy Problem: Destiny vs. Choice

Prophecy in romance adds an element of uncertainty because the question remains: if the prophecy says you will be together, then do you have a choice? If you don't have a choice, can this truly be considered love? As a whole, romance readers need to believe that love is something we choose and not some sort of predestined fate. The key to creating an effective story about prophesied love lies in the way the author makes the feeling of being destined seem like a choice.

In *From Blood and Ash*, the prophecy about the Maiden is misconstrued from the beginning; Poppy is led to believe she was destined for something that was never meant to be her actual destination. Similarly, in *ACOTAR* the mating bond serves as a type of divine fate, and characters must debate whether or not it takes away their ability to have control over their own lives through free will. Both examples allow the characters to maintain agency by making the prophecy a question, not an answer.

APPROACH	HOW IT WORKS
Prophecy is misinterpreted	They think it means one thing; it means another
Prophecy creates resistance	Knowing they're "fated" makes them fight it
Prophecy is conditional	Fate is invitation, not command
Prophecy doesn't mean happiness	Fated to meet, not to succeed

APPROACH	HOW IT WORKS
Multiple valid interpretations	Different readings create different expectations

Which approach are you using?

How you handle prophecy shapes whether love feels chosen or predetermined. Most satisfying romances preserve agency.

- ☐ The prophecy is misinterpreted: what they think it means isn't what it means
- ☐ The prophecy creates the problem: knowing they're "fated" makes them resist
- ☐ The prophecy is conditional: fate is invitation, not command; they still have to choose
- ☐ The prophecy doesn't guarantee happiness: fated to meet, not to love, not to succeed
- ☐ Multiple interpretations exist: different readings create different expectations

At what point do they choose each other despite or because of prophecy?

The moment where prophecy becomes choice, where destiny is claimed rather than passively received:

YOUR ANSWER

Can prophecy be avoided or changed?

If yes: how? At what cost? If prophecy can be defied, their choice to fulfil it means something.

YOUR ANSWER

Chosen Ones & Divine Purpose

Being chosen by the gods is a burden as much as a gift. Divine purpose competes with personal desire, and that's the tension: how do you have a life when you're supposed to be saving the world?

Is either character marked by divine favour, curse, or destiny?

Being chosen creates obligations that compete with personal desire. What does destiny demand that love can't give?

If your story has a 'chosen one': Which character is it? What marks them as chosen? What are they chosen to do?

YOUR ANSWER

How does divine purpose conflict with personal desire?

Does love distract from destiny? Does destiny require sacrifice of the relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

What happens if they refuse their divine purpose?

What are the stakes of saying no to the gods?

YOUR ANSWER

Religious Difference & Interfaith Love

When people from different faiths fall in love, they must navigate not just their own beliefs but each other's, and often, the mutual hostility between their religious communities.

Interfaith love creates challenges woven into daily life. Whose holidays do you celebrate? Which faith do you raise children in? When someone dies, whose death rituals bring comfort?

Do your characters practise different religions?

Interfaith love creates daily challenges beyond the initial obstacle: whose traditions, whose holidays, whose gods?

If yes:

What faith does each character follow?

YOUR ANSWER

What does each faith teach about the other?

Mutual hostility between faiths raises the stakes considerably. Mutual respect makes blending easier but may reduce tension.

What does each character's faith teach about the other character's faith or people?

YOUR ANSWER

What practical conflicts arise from different faiths?

Different holy days? Conflicting dietary laws? Different marriage requirements? Children: which faith to raise them in?

YOUR ANSWER

Would one need to convert for them to marry?

What would conversion mean: practical formality or genuine betrayal of belief?

YOUR ANSWER

Can they build a shared spiritual life, or will faith always divide them?

This question shapes the long-term viability of the relationship. Some couples find synthesis; others accept respectful difference.

YOUR ANSWER

Conversion & Religious Identity

When a character converts for love, changing faith, species, or worldview to be with their partner, the consequences are much greater than those of outside obstacles. Converting is about more than just adding a different label to your identity. It means rebuilding yourself. And in romantasy, this can literally occur: the human becomes a vampire, the mortal becomes a Fae, the priestess renounces her vows.

The difference lies between a genuine conversion and a hollow one. Genuine conversions involve a real transformation of how the character views themselves. They don't just change what they practice; they change how they see themselves and their purpose in life. In *From Sand and Ash*, Angelo's conversion from a Catholic priest to a man who will do anything to be with Eva is not portrayed as a rejection of his faith, but as the realisation of his true purpose, which is validated through great sacrifice. Hollow

conversions are done for the sake of expediency. The character will follow the procedures required to fulfil a legal or social obligation, however, there will be no real change in their perceptions of themselves. If a character “converts” to the rituals of a new culture merely to fit in with a partner, without the story showing the inner conflict the character experienced, the conversion will feel empty.

Another aspect to consider is guilt. The partner responsible for the conversion will have to carry the weight of having destroyed a part of the person they love - their heritage, their community, their connection to family and traditions. This guilt can be used as another source of romantic tension.

And perhaps the greatest subversion is the character who chooses not to convert. Miryem in *Spinning Silver* does not choose to assimilate into the cold world of the Staryk King, even though it would provide her with both wealth and influence. Instead, her decision to not conform to his expectations is what gives her a happy romantic ending. The most authentic conclusion is one where the character’s original identity is respected and incorporated, not rejected.

Does either character change faith, species, or worldview to be with their partner?

Conversion for love raises questions about authenticity, sacrifice, and identity.

If conversion is part of your story: Who converts and to what? Is it genuine or performed?

What do they lose? Does the other partner feel guilt? Is the conversion affirmed or regretted?

Does either character refuse to convert, and is that refusal honoured?

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE (*PRIORY OF THE ORANGE TREE*)
How does religion explain or relate to magic?		Sacred tree grants magic; dragons are holy, wyrms are evil
How does religion legitimise or conflict with government?		Queen rules by holy bloodline; Priory protects but operates outside the law
How do cultural taboos relate to religious law?		Celibacy is a Priory vow; breaking it means losing her place in the order
Could your characters use religion to legitimise their relationship?		She could argue love gave her strength, redefining faith to include it
Or does religion make legitimising impossible?		The vows are clear: serve the queen, not your heart. No loophole exists
Does a founding myth need to be dismantled for the romance to succeed?		The myth of Saint Galian must be exposed as a lie before Sabran can be free

Quick Reference: Religious Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE (PRIORY-STYLE)
Primary religious obstacle		Sworn to a celibate order; love means breaking sacred vows

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE (PRIORY-STYLE)
What faith demands		Lifelong virginity, devotion, protection of the queen
What they'd lose by violating religious law		Sisterhood, purpose, identity — everything she trained for
The prophecy (if applicable)		The Nameless One will rise; is love distraction or strength?
Key holy day or sacred time		The vigil before final vows: the last moment to choose
Religious consequence if they're together		Expulsion; seen as corrupted and fallen
The divine choice (when they must choose faith or love)		The world needs a warrior-priestess; she wants love
How religion resolves		She redefines faith: love as strength, not weakness
How magic and religion interact		Her magic is heresy in the West but keeps the Queen alive
Key ritual or ceremony		The vigil of final vows: commit or walk away
Is the beloved condemned by nature? (heretic love interest)		Her magic IS what the faith condemns, not just a rule broken

Final Thought

Faith Must Feel Real

Your characters may be religious whether you are or not. Their faith should feel genuine, not just an obstacle you created. Religious worldbuilding at its most effective allows readers to see why a person would give up their faith for someone they love, and why giving up faith would be a true loss for them. Faith gives a person comfort, community, identity, and purpose in life. So when a character risks giving all of those things up for love, it should hurt. Create a religion that is worthy of fighting for, or against, or to redefine entirely.